RSS upbringing that makes me do well whatever task I am entrusted with … I do not have a single instance of the Sangh parivar creating any problem for me. The Sangh parivar is with me. They have always backed me, helped me, guided me. The Sangh parivar is my eternal strength.'[40]

Similarly, as prime minister in 2000, Vajpayee told a VHP audience in New York, 'I may be Prime Minister today, may not be tomorrow. But one thing that nobody can rob me of is being a swayamsevak [literally self-helper, volunteer; also a term for Sangh workers].'[41]

His deputy prime minister, L.K. Advani, too, publicly proclaimed that 'if there is any admirable quality in me, I owe it to the RSS'.[42]

This is why, for anyone wishing to understand the growth of the BJP, it is vital to understand specifically what the RSS stands for and how it has evolved over time. This section of the book answers three broad sets of questions.

First, how much has the RSS grown over the years? What role does it play in political mobilisation? What are the mechanisms it uses to expand in new areas? What is the role of the wider Sangh Parivar in the BJP's expansion? What is the quantifiable role and influence of the RSS within the BJP and the governments it controls?

Second, which ideas does the RSS privilege most, and when? Which ones does it give importance to and which ones does it underplay? How does it communicate these ideas to different audiences? How does it calibrate its messaging at different times in the political cycle?

Chapters 12 and 14 answer the first set of questions. Chapter 12 provides a detailed analysis and macro picture of the RSS's national expansion over the past three decades. To delineate this further, it provides a case study of how the RSS grew in Karnataka between 2014 and 2020. It also puts together a new empirical analysis of the exact nature of the BJP–RSS linkages by quantifying, for the first time, exactly how many leaders with a verifiable RSS background occupy key positions within the BJP leadership, the Modi government and one major state government run by the BJP (Madhya Pradesh).